NBA Playoff Pool — PRD v1.1

Product Overview

NBA Playoff Pool is a private web application for a group of friends to compete through a structured prediction game during the NBA Playoffs. Players submit picks across multiple betting categories — from series winners to quirky side bets — and earn points based on accuracy. A live leaderboard tracks standings, and a real money pot rewards the winner.

The app is invite-only, run by a Commissioner who manages the group, and powered by an NBA data integration (BallDontLie API) that automatically updates scores as games are completed.

Field	Value
Product Name	NBA Playoff Pool App
Target Users	Private friend group (6–12 players)
Season	NBA 2025–26 Playoffs
Buy-in Model	Real money pot — Commissioner managed
Betting Windows	Mixed: early picks locked pre-playoffs; series bets open per round
Results Feed	Auto-pulled from NBA data API (BallDontLie)
Push Notifications	Firebase FCM (browser push)
Email Notifications	Resend
Leaderboard	Live, updates as games complete

Goals

- Create a fun, competitive experience around the NBA Playoffs for a private friend group
- Provide a fair and transparent scoring system with a clear point breakdown for every player
- Eliminate manual score tracking — results auto-update via NBA data feed

- Support a real money pot with clear Commissioner controls
- Keep the experience social with notifications, standings drama, and side bets

Non-Goals (v1)

- Public leagues or strangers joining
- Real-time in-game predictions (all bets are pre-series or pre-round)
- Native mobile app (web app only, mobile-responsive)
- Payment processing integration (Commissioner handles money manually)

User Roles

Commissioner

- Creates the pool and generates invite links
- Manages betting windows — opens and closes picks per round
- Oversees real money pot (collected and distributed manually outside the app)
- Can manually override or correct scores if the data feed has an error
- Designates the winner of the Dumbest Bet award at season end

Player

- Joins via invite link and creates a profile (nickname, avatar/emoji)
- Submits picks during open betting windows
- Views live leaderboard, their personal score breakdown, and other players' locked picks
- Receives push/email notifications on standings changes
- Votes on the Dumbest Bet at end of playoffs

Betting Structure & Windows

Early Picks (Pre-Playoffs, Locked at Tip-off)

Submitted before the playoffs begin. Cannot be changed once locked.

- **Conference Finalists** — Pick one team per conference to reach the Conference Finals → 2 pts each
- **NBA Finalists** — Pick one team per conference to reach the NBA Finals → 3 pts each
- **NBA Champion** — Pick the team that wins the championship → 5 pts
- **Finals MVP** — Pick the player who wins Finals MVP → 1 pt

Series Bets (Per Round, Opens Before Each Round)

For each series, players submit: the series winner and the exact series result (e.g. 4-1, 4-2, 4-3). Additionally, players choose one optional side bet per series.

Round	Series Winner	Exact Result
First Round	1 point	3 points
Second Round	2 points	5 points
Conference Finals	3 points	8 points
NBA Finals	4 points	10 points

Bonus Points on Exact Results

- Only 1 player hits the exact result → **+2 bonus points**
- Exactly 2 players hit the exact result → **+1 bonus point each**
- 3 or more players hit → no bonus

Per-Series Side Bets

For each series, each player selects exactly one side bet. Side bets are optional bonus layers — points are awarded in addition to standard scoring.

Side Bet	What to Predict	Points if Correct
Top Series Scorer 🏀	Which player averages the most PPG in the series	2 pts

Side Bet	What to Predict	Points if Correct
Exact Result Predictor ⭐	Same as standard exact result — chosen as side bet focus	Standard + bonus
Biggest Single-Game Margin 📊	Largest point differential in any one game	2 pts (closest wins)
Total Overtimes in Series ⏱️	Total OT periods across all games in the series	2 pts (exact = 3 pts)
Dumbest Bet 🤡	Your own wildcard prediction — group votes at end of playoffs	1 pt + bragging rights

Tiebreaker Rules

In the event of a tie in final standings, tiebreakers are applied in this order:

1. Most exact series results predicted correctly across the entire playoffs
2. FMVP pick correct (yes/no)
3. Earliest submission timestamp — first to lock in picks wins

Tiebreaker standings are always visible on the leaderboard so players can track their position in advance.

Leaderboard & Scoring Transparency

Live Leaderboard

- Updates automatically as NBA game results are ingested from the data feed
- Shows each player's: total points, rank, points gained today, and movement arrow (up/down)
- Tiebreaker rank visible as a secondary indicator when scores are equal
- Filters available: by round, by bet category

Personal Score Breakdown

Every player has a personal breakdown page showing exactly how they earned every point:

- Series-by-series: winner pick result, exact result, bonus, side bet

- Early picks: which came in, which missed
- Running total and projected max remaining points
- **Max possible points remaining** — shows each player's ceiling score assuming they win every remaining bet, so everyone knows if they're mathematically still in contention
- **Prediction accuracy %** — overall hit rate across all bets, shown on the player's profile
- **Best/worst series** — highlights which series was the player's highest and lowest scoring moment
- "What if" projector: shows how standings shift if a certain team wins their next series

Locked Picks Reveal

Once a round's betting window closes, all players' picks for that round are revealed simultaneously in a reveal screen — creating a shared group moment before games start.

Commissioner Quality of Life

- **Betting window countdown clock** — visible to all players on the betting screen, creating urgency as the deadline approaches
- **Nudge button** — Commissioner can send a one-click reminder notification to any player who hasn't submitted their picks yet for the current round
- **Auto-lock** — betting window closes automatically at a configured time, no manual action needed from the Commissioner

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Notifications

Players can opt in to push notifications (browser via Firebase FCM) and/or email alerts (via Resend). Notification triggers:

- 📈 Standings change — "Avi just jumped to 1st place with 14 pts"
- 🔒 Betting window closing soon — 24hr and 1hr warnings before a round locks

- 🏀 Series result in — "Warriors won the series 4-2, scores updated"
- 🎯 Bonus awarded — "You're the only one who nailed the exact result — +2 bonus!"
- 📋 Daily digest — optional end-of-day summary of scores and standings
- 🏆 Final results — full breakdown when the playoffs conclude

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Commissioner Tools

- Create the pool and generate a private invite link (shareable with friends)
- Open and close betting windows per round — with configurable deadlines
- Manual result override — correct a score if the NBA data feed has an error
- View all player submissions at any time (even before the reveal)
- Manage the real money pot ledger — track who has paid in (no payment processing, manual tracking)
- Announce Dumbest Bet winner — select from submitted wildcard bets, triggers group notification
- Export final standings as a PDF or image for sharing

User Experience Highlights

- Mobile-responsive web app — works on phones, no app install needed
- Invite-only — players join via a private link, no public sign-up
- Pick submission UI is clean and guided — shows point values inline as players choose
- Locked Bet Reveal is a dedicated screen with a countdown and animated reveal
- Each player picks a nickname and emoji/avatar for their profile
- Shareable end-of-season results card — a visual summary card players can screenshot and post
- Historical records tab — previous playoff pools stored for multi-year bragging rights (future)

NBA Data Integration

Recommended provider: **BallDontLie API** — free tier covers all needs, developer-friendly, with official JS/Python SDK.

Key auto-pull requirements:

- Series winners and exact results automatically detected when a series concludes
- Top scorer per series calculated from box score data
- Single-game point differentials tracked per game in each series
- Overtime periods tracked per game
- Play-In game results pulled as soon as games end

Commissioner retains manual override capability for data errors or edge cases.

Technical & Product Decisions

Decision	Choice	Notes
NBA Data Provider	BallDontLie API	Free tier, developer-friendly, covers all scoring needs
Push Notifications	Firebase FCM	Free, unlimited, works on web/iOS/Android
Email Notifications	Resend	Modern API, 3,000 emails/month free, best DX for new projects
Dumbest Bet Voting	Formal in-app voting	All players vote via in-app interface; results displayed publicly
Pick Visibility	Hidden until locked	Players see others' picks only after the round window closes
Missed Window	Score 0	No forfeits — unpicked bets simply score zero
Multi-Season Support	TBD	Architect flexibly in v1 but do not over-engineer from day one

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The Monkey 🐒

The Monkey is an automated dummy player that participates in every pool alongside real players. It submits fully randomized picks for every bet category,

serving as a humorous benchmark. Finishing below the Monkey is the ultimate indignity.

Behavior

- One Monkey per pool, automatically added when the pool is created
- Picks are fully randomized with no weighting or logic — pure coin flip for every bet
- Instantly submits all picks the moment a betting window opens
- Participates in all bet categories: Play-In, series bets, early picks, Finals MVP, and side bets
- Cannot be removed from the pool once created

Leaderboard Treatment

- Appears on the live leaderboard like any other player
- Has special animated visual treatment — e.g. animated monkey emoji, bouncing avatar, or a distinctly styled row
- Clearly labeled as The Monkey so it is never confused with a real player
- Counts in standings for rank calculation — finishing below the Monkey is a real, visible position

Pot & Prizes

- The Monkey is excluded from the real money pot — it cannot win regardless of final standings
- No special badge is awarded for beating the Monkey — motivation is purely avoiding the embarrassment of losing to it
- If the Monkey ranks 1st by points, it shows in first place on the leaderboard but the pot goes to the top-ranked human player

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